

A FREE SELF-AUDIT FROM COACH KAGISO

The South African CV Checklist

Fifteen checks that decide whether your CV gets seen.

Score your own CV in about ten minutes. Then fix what matters most.



COACHKAGISO
Career Development & Personal Brand Coach ·
coachkagiso.co.za

Before you start

Hello. I am Kagiso, your career development and personal brand coach. Most CVs do not fail because the person is not good enough. They fail because the CV is hard to read, Or it does not match the role, so it slips down the pile before anyone gives it a fair chance.

No software simply throws your CV away. The risk is quieter than that. If your CV cannot be read cleanly, or it does not speak to the role, it ranks low and a recruiter never reaches it. This checklist fixes that.

This is a self-audit, not a rewrite. By the end you will know exactly what is working on your CV and what is holding it back. The fixing comes after. This shows you where to start.

- **Green.** This is working for you.
- **Amber.** Worth a second look.
- **Red.** This is likely costing you interviews.

Work through the fifteen checks. Tick one light for each. When you reach the end, count your red marks. That number tells you how much work your CV needs, and what to do next.

SECTION A

How your CV gets read

The first read is fast, and it is often a machine before it is a person. These five checks make sure your CV can be read cleanly.

1

Your contact details sit at the top, in the body of the document, not inside a header or footer box.

- | | |
|--|--------------------------|
| ■ Green Name, cell number, professional email, city, and LinkedIn, all easy to find. | ☐ |
| ■ Amber Present, but tucked into a header or footer, or the email looks unprofessional. | ☐ |
| ■ Red Phone or email missing, or buried where it is hard to find. | ☐ |

2

Your CV is built in a single column, with no tables, text boxes, graphics, or icons.

- ☐ **Green** One clean column the whole way down.
- ☐ **Amber** One small table or a light graphic element.
- ☐ **Red** Two columns, built on tables, or skills shown as icons or bars.

3

Your section headings use standard labels, not creative titles.

- ☐ **Green** Work Experience, Education, Skills, and similar plain labels.
- ☐ **Amber** Slightly unusual, but the meaning is still clear.
- ☐ **Red** Creative labels such as My Journey or Where I Have Been.

4

Your CV is saved as a text-based file, never a scanned image.

- ☐ **Green** A Word document, or a text-based PDF exported from Word.
- ☐ **Amber** A PDF and you are not sure how it was made.
- ☐ **Red** A scan or a photo of a printed CV.

5

Your font is standard and a readable size, and the layout still works on a phone.

- ☐ **Green** A clean, common font that holds up on a small screen.
- ☐ **Amber** A little small or tight in places.
- ☐ **Red** A decorative font, very small text, or a layout that breaks on a phone.

What belongs on a South African CV

South African CVs carry their own rules. These five checks keep yours current and safe, and free of anything that invites bias or risk.

6

Your full ID number is left off, unless the application specifically asks for it.

Green No ID number on the CV.



Amber Only part of it shown.



Red Your full ID number is printed on the CV.



7

You have left off date of birth, age, marital status, dependants, and religion.

Green None of these appear.



Amber One of them is there and you are unsure about it.



Red Two or more of these are on your CV.



8

There is no race or ethnicity on your CV, and your nationality or right to work is stated in one line.

Green No race stated, and a clear line confirming your work eligibility.



Amber Neither stated. Fine for citizens, but add the one-line work-eligibility note.



Red Your race or ethnicity is stated on the CV.



9

Your photo choice fits the role.

Green No photo for a corporate or online application, or a professional headshot for a role that expects one.



Amber A photo included where you are not certain it is expected. This is a judgement call, not a failure. **JUDGEMENT CALL**



Red A casual, cropped, or social-media photo.



10

Your references are handled deliberately.

Green "Available on request" with your referees ready, or named referees where the sector expects them.



Amber Referees listed before you have asked their permission. A judgement call by sector.

JUDGEMENT CALL



Red No references, and none lined up to give if asked.



SECTION C

What makes a recruiter shortlist you

Once your CV is readable, it has to earn the shortlist. These five checks are what a recruiter is actually looking for.

11

You have a short professional summary, two to four lines, in the top third, written for the specific role.

Green A tight summary that speaks to the job you are applying for.



Amber A summary, but generic and not tailored.



Red No summary, or an old-style objective about what you want.



12

Your experience runs in reverse chronological order, with Month Year dates, and any gap over six months is accounted for.

Green Most recent first, clear dates, gaps explained in a line.



Amber Dates shown as years only.



Red Out of order, or a long gap with no explanation.



13

Your achievements are written as results, not a list of duties.

Green Outcomes, with numbers where you have them.



Amber A mix of results and duties.



Red Only duties, such as "Responsible for" lines.



14 The skills and words from the advert are reflected naturally in your CV.

■ **Green** The role's key terms appear where they are true for you. ☐

■ **Amber** Some overlap with the advert. ☐

■ **Red** One generic CV that you send to everything. ☐

15 Your qualifications show institution, year, and NQF level where it matters, and your languages show proficiency.

■ **Green** Clear qualifications with NQF where relevant, and languages with levels. ☐

■ **Amber** Listed, but missing NQF levels or proficiency. ☐

■ **Red** Vague, incomplete, or missing. ☐



One last pass. Read your CV out loud for spelling and grammar, set your spell check to UK or South African English rather than US, and save the file as Name_Surname_CV. Small things, but they shape the first impression.

Now count your reds

0 to 1 red

Your CV is in good shape. Tidy up the ambers, keep it tailored to each role, and keep applying with confidence.

2 to 4 reds

There is real work to do here. These are the issues most likely to be costing you interviews. Fix them before you send your CV out again.

5 or more reds

Your CV is working against you right now. The good news is that this is the fastest win available to you. A clear, well-built CV changes the response you get.

The next step

If you would like a professional set of eyes on your CV, that is what I do. I offer CV reviews and full revamps, built for the South African market and the way recruiters here actually read. See how to work with me at coachkagiso.co.za/work-with-me. And if you reply to the email this came in on and tell me your score, I read those myself.



Show up. Stand out. Level up.

Your career matters. Keep elevating.

Coach Kagiso

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